China in the Yasuní

The Chinese presence in Yasuní territory is emblematic for at least three reasons: first, as the most biodiverse place in the world, the park contains immense biological and social wealth and is also the territorial space of indigenous peoples among whom the Tagaeri and Taromenane stand out for their voluntary isolation; secondly, because the area has acquired significance both within the country and abroad due to the society's desire to keep crude oil in the ground in one part of the territory, a proposal at first welcomed by the government but later discarded; and thirdly, because of the violent form that exportation from this region has taken.

On 18 March 2007, SINOPEC together with Petrobras and ENAP of Chile signed a memorandum of understanding with the Ecuador government for the exploitation of Ishpingo-Tambococha-Tiputini (ITT, having one-fifth of Ecuador's reserves). The operational plan, developed by SINOPEC, established in eight clauses the requirements 'for the development and production' of the fields in the ITT block.

Two options were put forward: Plan A proposed no petroleum extraction from Yasuní-ITT while Plan B, the oil companies' proposal, was fronted by the then Energy Minister Alberto Acosta and by the head of Petroecuador, Carlos Pareja Yannuzzelli. Led by the President of the Republic, Petroecuador's Administrative Council decided to keep both options open. Although Plan A was declared to have priority, it was decided to go ahead with Plan B's conditions for exploitation. It was pointed out that the option of Plan A would always be considered when the international community contributed at least half of the funds that ITT oil extraction would generate.

The press release from that meeting of 1 April 2007 signalled that the first option – that of not exploiting the fields – was based on the arguments not to disturb an area of extraordinary biodiversity and not to put at risk the existence of the various Tagaeri and Taromenane peoples who were in voluntary isolation. The existence of these two peoples who formed part of the Wuaorani nation had been identified by reports but it was also characterised by violent incidents. The 2008 Constitution protected the territories of these 'voluntarily isolated peoples' and ensured that violation of their rights 'would constitute a crime of genocide'. However, for various sectors of civil and political society the hazards persisted.

Another fact scandalised the country's public opinion: the publication by the English newspaper, *The Guardian,* of a document that proved that the Chinese credit negotiations included conditions for Ecuador favouring Chinese investment in the ITT block and Block 31 (*The Guardian*, 19 March 2014). These negotiations were taking place in periods when the Ecuadorian state was still